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Flight Ready Boeing supplies nearly 90% of Air India's long-haul aircraft

and solutions wherever possible,” says an AAHL spokesperson. “We were one of the first airport operators to deploy Made in India baggage security screening machines. We have also developed an in-house automation platform — Aviiio—to automate entire operations.”

It remains an exception in a landscape where the overwhelming architecture—from ATM radars to biometric boarding systems—is sourced from abroad.

M.V. Nahusharaj, former Global Head of Recruitment and Management Development with Air India, explains why the pattern of foreign dominance at ground level is not accidental. “Indian airports utilise

foreign ground handlers primarily to manage rapid growth, bringing in expertise in safety and complex logistics management,” he says. According to Nahusharaj, the government also encourages foreign direct investment, and hence more services are being offered by foreign ground support companies.

The radar network overseeing aircraft through Indian airspace is the product of Indra Sistemas, a Spanish aerospace company. Its network covers 80% of India's airspace—nine Monopulse Secondary Surveillance Radars, 38 tower automation systems at 38 airports, and the two most critical Area Control Centres, Delhi and Kolkata, according to its own docu-

mentation. In March 2023, AAI awarded Indra a contract worth more than €55 million to expand its operations into Mumbai, Hyderabad, Bangalore, Navi Mumbai, and Mopa.

India's DigiYatra biometric boarding programme operates on SITA's Swiss face-recognition hardware, supported by an app developed in partnership with the Indian company Data Evolve. In July 2023, SITA announced a landmark agreement with the AAI covering 43 airports and more than 2,700 passenger touchpoints.

THE CORNER OFFICE

The pilot shortage in India is structural. The DGCA issues 1,200 to